

OP-ED: SUCCESSION - A REINCARNATION OF SHAKESPEARE'S

KING LEAR?

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Corporate boardrooms can feel a lot like old school royal courts where a single move can topple an empire. Shakespeare's *King Lear* and HBO's *Succession* both open with powerful fathers demanding loyalty, only to unleash chaos. By comparing these two stories I would say that a lust for power combined with a craving for public validation is chipping away at genuine empathy and trust among the patriarch and family.



Figure 1 - S1 Ending w/ Logan displaying his ruthlessness

One pivotal moment in Episode 1 perfectly illustrates this dynamic. In private during his birthday celebration, Logan warns Kendall that he is “just concerned that you are still soft” (*Succession* 1.1), a critique that mirrors Lear’s fear of weakness when he demands public protestations from his daughters.

Moments later Lawrence shatters Kendall’s veneer with “I’m not letting you Neanderthals in to rape my company. Ever” (*Succession* 1.1), exposing the limits of Kendall’s authority and validating Logan’s judgment. Just as Lear repudiates Cordelia by declaring “Here I disclaim all my paternal care” (*King Lear* 1.1), Logan allows this public undoing to demonstrate that he is still in control and that Kendall needs to follow along. Both fathers treat loyalty as a performance and punish honesty, ensuring that genuine trust gives way to fear and resentment. Had Cordelia professed her love to Lear just as Kendall become more locked in at work, things may have changed.

I find it fascinating that both Lear and Logan demand grandiose shows of affection to confirm what they already suspect: their legacy is on shaky ground. For Lear, this insecurity is magnified by his advancing age and fraying senses. He seems haunted by fears of losing relevance. Logan, on the other hand, is grappling with a massive business empire that needs clear leadership. Instead of parchment decrees, Logan uses press releases and board meetings, but the underlying tension is the same. Lear ends up raging in a storm, lamenting betrayal, while Logan lashes out at his children behind closed doors. These kings of different eras make the same mistake: they hinge on their self-worth or unquestioning loyalty.

Why does this centuries old struggle still grip us? In my view, the universal tension between power and family bonds never stops resonating. Shakespeare frames it with a thunderous storm; Succession places it in sleek offices. Yet the essence is the same: when power overshadows love, betrayal and tragedy loom. Goneril and Regan flatter Lear until it serves their plans, with the same being applied by Roy's children towards Logan by using words he wants. It's essentially glazing their father to harbor their own ambitions. Once the father's authority slips, the children see an opening to seize control.

With the progression of Succession, while Logan's health slips further, Kendall's struggles underscore the tragedy. His cocaine addiction reveals his deep vulnerability even as he jockeyes for power. He tries to prove himself worthy of the throne Logan dangles before him, but drugs and desperation cloud his judgment. In the same way that Lear's rage and pride distort his perspective, Kendall's attempts to self-medicate only drive him further from genuine connection with his father. Once again it shows how bad health whether it is physical or mental can cloud judgement which is seen with Lear's irrational behavior against Cordelia. Parallels among the show and Shakespeare's work continue to go from start to finish.

By the end of Succession, Logan's sudden death leaves his children scrambling to fill the void, echoing the devastation that follows Lear's collapse. Both stories remind us that the real tragedy



Figure 2 – S4 Finale depicting Kendall as “The Prince Who Never Became King”

is not just the patriarch's demise, but the emotional wreckage that remains. Lear dies with Cordelia in his arms, shattered by the consequences of his pride. Logan's heirs are equally broken, confronted by the reality that their father perhaps never truly trusted them.

The heartbreak of these endings is that much of the suffering could have been prevented if genuine relationships had mattered more than ironclad control.

I believe this parallel is why King Lear endures and why Succession resonates. We watch these patriarchs, who should be mentors, become insecure tyrants. We see children who should be heirs devolve into rivals and ultimately fall short of their goals. In the end, true loyalty, as both stories show, is not something that can be coerced.

These stories remind us that leaders who lack awareness of their own faults are destined to fail. If Lear and Logan had shown empathy and humility, their families might have held together instead of falling apart. Each instead demanded public displays of loyalty and set off cycles of fear and betrayal. Therefore, Shakespeare's theme of ambition must be balanced by compassion, or the very legacy one strives to preserve may implode from within.

“This assignment is all my own writing and ideas. No generative AI technologies were used.”